

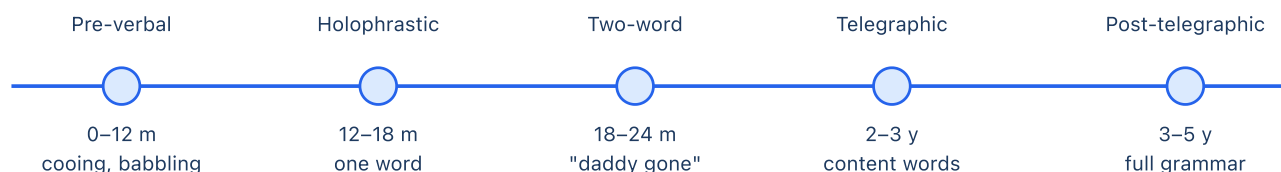
● RAG Learning

2.1 Children's Spoken Language Development

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 2 Child Language

Paper 2 assesses your ability to analyse how children acquire their first language between birth and around age 8. You need to know the **stages** of phonological, lexical, grammatical and pragmatic development, the major **theorists** (Skinner, Chomsky, Piaget, Vygotsky, Bruner, Halliday, Tomasello), and how to apply all of this to an unseen transcript. The paper is 1 hour 15 minutes and worth 20% of the A-level.

Stages of Spoken Language Development (approximate ages)



2.1.1 Stages of Development

Pre-verbal (0–12 months)

- Crying / reflexive vocalisation (0–2 months).
- Cooing (2–5 months) — vowel-like sounds.
- Babbling (6–12 months) — reduplicated syllables ("bababa"), then variegated.
- By 12 months, babbling narrows to phonemes of the ambient language.

Holophrastic / one-word (12–18 months)

Single words function as whole utterances. "Milk" might mean "I want milk", "that is milk", "where is the milk". Context disambiguates. Nelson (1973): first-50-word vocabulary dominated by **specific nominals** (mummy, doggy).

Two-word stage (18–24 months)

Two content words in consistent semantic relations: *daddy gone, more juice, no bed*. Word order is typically target-like.

Telegraphic stage (2–3 years)

Three+ content words, function words (articles, auxiliaries, inflections) often omitted: *daddy gone shop, me want biscuit*.

Post-telegraphic (3–5 years)

Function words appear; tense, aspect and agreement become regular; embedded clauses emerge; questions with subject–auxiliary inversion develop. By school age most core grammar is acquired.

2.1.2 Phonological Development

- **Cluster reduction** — "poon" for "spoon".
- **Substitution** — /w/ for /r/, /d/ for /ð/.
- **Deletion** of unstressed syllables — "nana" for "banana".
- **Assimilation** — "doggy" → "goggy".
- **Fis phenomenon** — child says "fis" for "fish" but rejects an adult saying "fis" — perception leads production.

2.1.3 Lexical and Semantic Development

- **Overextension** — a word used too broadly: "dog" for all four-legged animals.
- **Underextension** — a word used too narrowly: "dog" only for the family pet.
- **Mismatch errors** — unrelated reference.

- **Vocabulary spurt** — around 18 months.

2.1.4 Grammatical Development & Virtuous Errors

A **virtuous error** is an overgeneralisation of a rule: "goed", "mouses". The child has never heard these forms; they are produced by applying a rule. Decisive evidence against pure imitation.

The **Berko wug test** (1958) showed children reliably plural a novel "wug" as "wugs" — productive knowledge of the plural morpheme.

2.1.5 Pragmatic Development & Halliday's Functions

Function	Purpose	Example
Instrumental	Getting needs met	"want juice"
Regulatory	Controlling others' behaviour	"no bed"
Interactional	Maintaining social bonds	"hi mummy"
Personal	Expressing feelings / identity	"me happy"
Heuristic	Exploring / learning	"what's that?"
Imaginative	Play / fantasy	"I'm a dragon"
Representational	Conveying information	"doggy barking"

2.1.6 Theories of Acquisition

Behaviourism — Skinner

Children learn through imitation, operant conditioning, and positive reinforcement. **Evaluation:** cannot explain virtuous errors or novel utterances; rarely receive explicit correction yet still

converge on adult grammar.

Nativism — Chomsky

Innate **Language Acquisition Device (LAD)** and **Universal Grammar**. Evidence: poverty of the stimulus, virtuous errors, critical period (Lenneberg), universals across languages.

Cognitive — Piaget

Language depends on underlying cognitive development. Children cannot use a concept linguistically before they have grasped it cognitively. Limitation: Vygotsky shows language can drive cognition too.

Social interactionism — Bruner, Vygotsky

- **Bruner (LASS)** — Language Acquisition Support System: joint attention, recasting, expansion, routines.
- **Vygotsky (ZPD)** — the gap between what a learner can do alone and with guidance.
- **Trevarthen** — proto-conversations: pre-verbal turn-taking with gaze and vocalisation.
- **Tomasello** — usage-based theory: grammar learned from patterns; shared intentionality is central.

2.1.7 Child-Directed Speech (CDS)

Caregivers' register with infants:

- Higher pitch, exaggerated intonation.
- Slower tempo, clearer articulation.
- Simplified, concrete vocabulary.
- Repetition and routines.
- Recasting — repeating the child's utterance in full form.
- Expansion — adding information to what the child said.
- Reference to the here-and-now supporting joint attention.

Applied Example: A picture-book routine at 18 months exemplifies multiple theories at once: joint attention (Bruner), exaggerated prosody (CDS), labelling supporting Halliday's heuristic function, scaffolding within the ZPD (Vygotsky), and input that activates innate capacity (Chomsky). Top-band exam answers weave several theorists together.

2.1.8 Key Evidence

Genie (Curtiss, 1977)

Girl isolated from language until age 13. After rescue she acquired lexis but not complex grammar — cited as evidence for the critical period. Caveats: single case, trauma as confound.

Jim (hearing child of deaf parents)

Exposed to language mainly through TV, failed to acquire full grammar. Shows input alone is not enough; *interactional* input is essential.

Tomasello's studies

Infants track speaker intention from around 12–14 months; shared intentionality is central to word learning.

2.1.9 Analysing a Transcript

1. Estimate the **stage** from utterance length, grammar, lexis.
2. Note **phonological** features.
3. Analyse **lexis / semantics** (over/underextensions, vocabulary choice).
4. Analyse **grammar / morphology** (word order, inflections, virtuous errors, subordination).
5. Apply **Halliday's functions**.
6. Consider **caregiver scaffolding** (recasting, expansion, questioning).
7. Apply **two theorists** explicitly, anchoring each claim in the transcript.

Exam Tip: Don't just name-drop theorists. Anchor each theoretical claim in specific features of the transcript. "The child says 'I goed' — a virtuous error showing rule over-generalisation. This supports Chomsky's nativist account: the child cannot have imitated a form they have never heard."

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **pre-verbal / holophrastic / two-word / telegraphic / post-telegraphic stages, babbling, cooing, overextension, underextension, virtuous error, wug test, CDS (motherese), recasting, expansion, LAD, LASS, ZPD, joint attention, critical period, Halliday's seven functions, fis phenomenon, Genie, Tomasello, proto-conversation.**